✦ STEP 8

Debate Skills

The lessons that came up again and again while preparing this topic.

✧ 1. Claim → Proof → So what

Every argument needs all three. If you skip the "so what," the judge will think: "Okay... why should I care?"

Part	Example
Claim	Recognizing Somaliland could encourage other regions to break away.
Proof	Groups like the English-speaking regions in Cameroon already want to.
So what	That could lead to instability and more fighting in Africa.

✧ 2. Don't claim more than you can prove

❌ Overclaim	✅ Defendable
"It would cause terrorism in the U.S."	"It could put Americans in East Africa at risk."
"Recognition would not cause other breakaways."	"Recognition wouldn't set an example for other regions."
"Somaliland doesn't know its own borders."	"Somaliland doesn't control all the land it claims."
"Almost all U.S. allies are democracies."	"Many of America's closest allies, like the UK and Japan, are democracies."
"We'd get all the ports."	"Its president has offered the U.S. access to Berbera."
"The U.S. would gain dominance."	"The U.S. would gain presence and influence."
"Somalia would stop fighting al-Shabaab."	"Somalia could stop working with the U.S. against al-Shabaab."

Helpful words: **could**, **one reason**, **experts say**, **according to**.

✧ 3. Name names

Vague words like "they," "fight" and "danger" make the judge guess. Specific words make you sound like you know your stuff.

- Say **"al-Shabaab,"** not "terrorism."
- Say **"Berbera,"** not "many ports."
- Say **"in 1960"** and **"in 2024,"** not "before" and "recently."
- Say **"the English-speaking regions in Cameroon,"** not "other countries."

✧ 4. Think one step ahead

Every argument goes back and forth. Before a round, ask yourself: "What will they say to this, and what will I say back?"

NEG "If Somaliland breaks away, others will copy it."

AFF "Somaliland is different. It was a separate colony and briefly independent."

NEG "Other groups won't care about those details. They'll see that breaking away worked. And even Somaliland's own borders are disputed."

✧ 5. Your case is a table with several legs

When they attack one reason, don't over-defend it. Say it's **one** of your reasons, then point to your others.

✧ 6. Use the other side's own sources

If Somaliland's friends say "we're unique," the judge thinks "of course they'd say that." If Somaliland's **opponents** (the AU) said it, the judge thinks "wow, even they admit it."

✧ 7. End with a sharp question

A rhetorical question puts the other side on the spot:

- "Somaliland doesn't even control all the land it claims, so **which borders would the U.S. be recognizing?**"
- "We're already getting the benefits, so **why take the risks?**"

✧ 8. Building your speech

Like the school-provided openings, use **two contentions** per side:

	Contention 1	Contention 2
AFF	It's already a real, democratic country	Its case is unique, so it won't spark more breakaways
NEG	We already get the benefits	It risks the fight against al-Shabaab

For each contention: **tag** → **explanation in your own words** → **evidence card** → **so what**.

✧ Before the round

- ◇ Every argument has a claim, proof and so what
- ◇ No overclaims ("could," not "will")
- ◇ Specific names, places and dates
- ◇ Tags written in my own words
- ◇ "Somalia" (country) vs. "Somali" (describing word) proofread
- ◇ Every VERIFY item checked or removed
- ◇ Practiced the cross-ex questions out loud
